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Child Welfare already employs uniform procedures through “No wrong door” and “Single Point of Access”. The goals of “One county: One application process” are as follows:

- ◆ Apply at any office
- ◆ Same-day application registry and immediate needs screening
- ◆ Same-day/next-day interviews
- ◆ Uniform and simplified processes for all offices

As a result of the pandemic, on line applications are also encouraged when possible for the convenience and safety of residents. As CMIC continues to reduce the burden on field staff, workers in the district offices not attached to application/certification units will concentrate on timely processing of recertification applications.

SNAP: SNAP benefits will have increased approximately 3.5% per household size effective October 1, 2023; i.e. from \$281 to \$291 for a household of one. Benefit amounts are subject to review and modification every October 1, when SUA (Standard Utility Allowance) allowances are announced by NYS OTDA SNAP. Able-Bodied Adults Without Dependents (ABAWD) continue to be exempt from work requirements through February 28, 2025. An Elderly Simplified Application Project (ESAP) and New York State Combined Application Project (NYSCAP) is available for elderly and single SSI recipients to access the SNAP program. Households that are eligible for ESAP and NYSCAP are authorized for a 3-year period. Recertification mail continues to be directed to a separate post office box to facilitate scanning and indexing of the entire application with documentation prior to electronic assignment to an eligibility worker for a determination. SNAP skimming and phishing fraud has continued to jeopardize food security of victimized SNAP recipients. “Skimming” is when a skimmer is used to copy information and “phishing” is unsolicited emails to trick customers into giving away their pin and card number. As a result of the skimming and phishing occurrences, NYS OTDA SNAP has implemented a workflow to replace SNAP benefits lost due to skimming/phishing if/when the loss claim is deemed creditable via NYS OTDA SNAP electronic verification(s). SNAP continues to participate in the limited interview waivers through 10/31/2024. There is currently an administrative waiver on certain SNAP over issuances during the period of 03/01/20-09/30/2023. However, waiver is not valid for properly adjudicated IPV's and any quality control/ AQ&I audit findings. Districts are required to calculate and report to NYS

SNAP bureau liaison the estimated number and value of all pandemic related over issuances that were waived. There is a ABAWD time limit extension impacting the 3 month in 36-month grace period, where households continue to receive SNAP benefits even though there is no ABAWD participation through 02/28/2025. Districts are required to accurately track employment codes throughout the waiver period.

Child Care Assistance: Westchester offers both a community Child Care Assistance program and a Scholarship for Westchester families. This scholarship meets local child care needs of hundreds of working families who would not otherwise qualify for Child Care Assistance. Westchester also supports child care to assist in Preventative case management toward creating the best outcome for children. Westchester is a state leader in Child Care Assistance and is frequently chosen by OCFS to act as a pilot county for such initiatives as development of online application portal and direct deposit payments. Westchester staff are active in the community serving on a Child Care Task Force, Head Start Committee, Healthy Families Board and the district's 0-6 Integrated Service Planning Board to promote services and quality of life for young children in Westchester

Office of Temporary Housing Assistance: The Office of Temporary Housing Assistance (OTHA) consists of the following divisions: U.S. Department and Urban Development (HUD) and Continuum of Care (CoC) Programs; Eligibility & Temporary Housing Assistance (THA) Placement; Casework Services; Contract Management & Shelter Compliance; and Payments & THA Program. While the eligibility and program/contracts divisions are not new, the two homeless casework services units in OTHA are now in place more than 10 years and the retention unit is in its 3rd full year. These service units continue to work directly with homeless families and those at risk of homelessness. Caseworkers develop realistic independent living plans and use a team approach for upfront assessment coordination for all new homeless families placed in the shelter system. In April 2022, OTHA unveiled the Retention Unit created to prevent recidivism of newly housed homeless families returning to the shelter system. The department's HUD & CoC programs receive over 8 Million Dollars in Federal Funding annually, which is designated to provide permanent housing and other support services to homeless families and individuals.

The overall Temporary Assistance homeless caseload has seen some changes in 2024. The homeless average caseload has increased by 45

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cases from 495 cases in June 2023 to 540 cases in June 2024. The Office of Temporary Housing Assistance has 190 units in the Emergency Housing Assistance Program (EHAP). The EHAPs continue to accommodate the County's need for Transitional Housing and Domestic Violence apartments. Beginning June 30, 2018, the department decided to keep the County's designated drop-in facilities open 24 hours during extreme hot and humid weather conditions. Currently the drop-in facilities operate on a continuous 24 hour schedule. Eviction Prevention Services will also be expanding with the addition of an Office of Housing Council and housing legal representation project.

Fair Hearings: Beginning in March 2014 and continuing through the present, the Fair Hearings Unit, now centrally located in White Plains, has been clearing its backlog of cases by taking advantage as often as possible of new space that permits dual calendars on a given day. The Fair Hearings Unit was continuing to utilize dual calendars in order to prevent future backlogs until the Pandemic when we began to hold single calendars. As a result of the COVID crisis and the number of waivers that were put in place by the Federal/State governments, there was a decrease in hearing requests and reduced the need for double calendars. For example, the requirement for face-to-face interviews in Temporary Assistance was removed, the automatic updates of SNAP cases by waiving recertification, as well as the increase in UIB for households all contributed to the change. There is an average of 243 hearings scheduled per month with an average request rate of 323 hearings scheduled per month. As of July 31, 2024 the backlog for the period of 2019 through 2023 is 1,295 hearings, as a result of scheduling changes by the Office of Administrative Hearings caused by the lifting of the state of emergency pandemic. All pended hearings continue to be scheduled. The NYS Department of Health has implemented a waiver called the "Unwind of Medical Assistance" regulations. All MA hearings regarding discontinuance or reduction of benefits were automatically getting aid to continue. Any aid to continue during the unwind period is not recoupable. The administrative law judge was also given additional time (after the 90-day period) to issue their decision. The Unit is working with all program areas to hold preconference hearings and reduce the need for an actual Fair Hearing. The Program Office also continues to provide training on the skills of all eligibility staff in preparation of materials and presentation when required to witness at a Fair Hearing. On June 26, 2017 WCDSS began the process of reinstating the use of video conferencing for all the WC district offices. While the state of emergency caused by the Covid 19

pandemic has come to an end, all ALJ's can still be teleworking. Therefore, most Fair Hearings are currently being heard over the telephone. Office of Administrative Hearings are scheduling some in-person hearings upon the request of the appellant and hearings that require home visits. The Office of Fair Hearing has developed a second Hearing Room in order to allow witnesses to remain in their own offices providing improved utilization of time by further decreasing the need for travel to and from the offices.

Office of Work Activities: (OWA) This area is the employment division of the department for Temporary Assistance applicants and recipients. OWA is comprised of specialist units of Employment Counselors and Eligibility Examiners who promote well-being and self sufficiency among individuals and families as well as implement and support Welfare to Work Program policies and procedures. OWA continues engaging customers by telephone and, as of November 2023, has started engaging clients in-person with referrals to employment, vocational education, educational training and CWEP which lead to participation and engagement. These two factors are what NYS OTDA looks at for each County. Employment Counselors are completing all Employment Orientations and initial Employment Assessments for TA applicants and 12-month reassessments for recipients. The engagement process also included referrals for further mental and/or medical health evaluations using contractor IMA (Industrial Medicine Associates) to help determine employability. Due to the need for safety but also to ensure that customers were receiving treatment services, OWA proposed tele-health psychological visits and IMA created a means to conduct these evaluations using Zoom. These evaluations continue to be used in addition to in-person appointments. OWA also continues to schedule virtual substance abuse assessments which are conducted by our partners, the Department of Community Mental Health's (DCMH) CASACs. OWA and DCMH use a shared outlook calendar that allows workers to schedule appointments. The overarching goal of OWA is to assist Temporary Assistance customers in securing employment through training, job search, and job readiness services. This requires making appropriate matches when referring the customer to the appropriate work activity and involves OWA staff working in conjunction with offices such as Family Investment, Child care, OPI, and OTHA to make sure the client is receiving the utmost attention and care by their employment worker. The Eligibility unit of OWA conducts special projects while also monitoring the exempt population. They are a critical piece in aiding the customer in securing supportive services such as child care, clothing, transportation and any

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additional services needed to support them in their path to self-sufficiency. Many of these transactions were performed via telephone and email. OWA's eligibility unit has also taken on a TA caseload including earned income cases across all district offices as well as employability cases from Yonkers. In addition, OWA contracts with Westhab, a non-profit organization that provides job development and case management services to our non-exempt customers. Maximus is OWA's contractor for the permanently unemployable population and assists with applying/securing SSI. OWA, DCMH CASACs and the contractor staff are co-located in district offices, allowing ease of access to services for the customers. As of November 2023, OWA has continued its partnership with CWEP providers including Westchester County Parks, Westchester County Finance and Yonkers Office of Aging. OWA will continue to expand their CWEP providers throughout 2024/2025 to provide clients with valuable on the job experience that will lead to self-sufficiency. During 2024/2025, the Office of Work Activities will continue to strengthen its partnership with Westchester Community College's (WCC) Job STAR Program located on the WCC campus to assist our customers with basic education, computer applications and vocational skills training programs. Jobstar has added additional programs to its contract for 2024/2025 including ESL, GED for Spanish Speakers, and tuition grants for clients that want to take part in other WCC programs that are not affiliated with Jobstar.

In order to meet the federal mandate of engaging ABAWDs in a work activity, OWA has a staff person co-located at the Career Center. This person conducts orientations and assigns customers to qualifying work activities to meet ABAWD requirements. ABAWD has been waived until February 2025. All OWA staff co-located in the Career Centers have been cross-trained in Career Center operating systems and processes. Essentially, they are the Temporary Assistance customer's direct link to the current job market and emerging job trends. Upon application for Temporary Assistance, the customers are referred to the Career Center for orientation, job search, training or any of the other various resources the Career Center has to offer. In addition to OWA staff, Westhab has staff co-located at the Career Center to provide customers guidance and referral to programs through WPWDB.

Westchester Career Center Network (formerly known as the One-Stop Employment Center)/Westchester-Putnam Workforce Development Board (WPWDB): is designed to provide a full range of assistance to job

seekers under one roof. Authorized under the Workforce Innovation and Opportunities Act of 2014 (WIOA), the centers offer a myriad of services to help individuals overcome barriers to employment and become self-sufficient. Services include training referrals, career counseling, electronic job bank listings, employment workshops and resume assistance for job seekers. In addition, the career centers provide recruitment services, labor market information and tax credit programs for employers. Located in Mt. Vernon, White Plains, Peekskill, and Carmel (Putnam County), the staff provide services to individuals who are unemployed, underemployed and/or needing a career change. Partnerships with the NYS Department of Labor, NYS Education Department, Adult Career & Continuing Education Services, Office of Children and Family Services, NYS Commission for the Blind, Senior Community Service Employment Programs, Community Services Block Grants Programs and Temporary Assistance for Needy Families Programs provide a seamless delivery system of programs and services to promote a universal approach to providing effective workforce assistance to job seekers and businesses. In program year 2023-24 (ending June 30, 2024), 1,407 customers attended job readiness workshops (including virtual workshops); 761 job seekers secured employment; and 50 job fairs were held attracting 1,835 employers and 15,829 job seekers. The WPWDB provides oversight and guidance to the network.

Workforce Development Academy for Youth (WDAY): The WDAY program serves 350 youth and young adults, ages 18-24, facing barriers to employment and education in Westchester and Putnam Counties. It focuses on supporting participants in attaining life-skills, in-demand occupational skills, and employment readiness necessary in today's job market. The program offers resources and services that help youth build the skills needed to explore and develop careers, pursue education opportunities and acquire occupational training. In PY23 (July 1, 2023 - June 30, 2024) 310 participants were enrolled in the WDAY program, 107 gained employment, and 131 received occupational training.

WPWDB Summer Youth Employment Program (SYEP): The SYEP operates from May to September, assisting youth in obtaining valuable workforce experience in a safe and productive environment. The program subsidizes wages for youth aged 14-21 who work with employers during the summer, including job readiness training and financial literacy. Once youth have met the eligibility requirements, employment is secured through one of

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thirteen community partners. In program year 2024, the program aims to place 380 individuals in jobs across the private sector, public sector, public sector and non-for-profit work sites during the summer months.

WPWDB Youth Employment Program (YEP): The YEP seeks to reduce community gun violence and youth criminal justice involvement by providing year-round employment opportunities. This program operated from September 2023 to June 2024, assisting youth to obtain valuable workforce experience in a safe and productive environment. The program subsidizes wages for youth aged 14-21 who work with employers 10 months of the year through one of four community partners. In program year 2023, the program enrolled 116 individuals (116% of goal) and placed 97 in jobs (97% of goal) across the private sector, public sector, public sector and non-for-profit work sites.

The Gun Violence Prevention Extension Program (GVP): The GVP extension allowed three community partners to continue to accomplish the goals of the program. Given limited funding available for this phase of the program, the partners focused on enrolling existing youth in trainings and supportive services, including laundry gift cards, driver's license applications and transportation vouchers, all aimed at gaining employment.

The Volunteer Income Tax Assistance program (VITA): helps low- and middle-income individuals and families prepare their federal and state tax returns. VITA helps residents take advantage of the Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC) and all tax credits for which they are eligible including child and education tax credits. The program assists individuals and families and benefits the County tax revenue since it is estimated that approximately 80% of refunds are spent locally helping to boost the County's economy. The number of VITA sites were increased from six to nine for the 2024 tax season. Mt. Vernon high school students were among those assisting taxpayers, along with 119 VITA volunteers. During the 2024 tax season, the program prepared and e-filed tax returns for 1,750 Westchester residents, who received \$1.8 million in federal refunds, including \$596,346 in earned income tax credits.

Quality Assurance: The Director of Temporary Assistance and Program Administrators within the Central Program Office (OTFS) and the Medicaid Program Office have continued to respond to audits conducted by the NYS Office of Disability Assistance of TA and SNAP, as well as the Department of Health (DOH) and the Office of the Medicaid Inspector General (OMIG) in

ongoing efforts to improve customer service while ensuring compliance with federal, state and local mandates. In 2024, OTFS participated in the following audits: SNAP ME, SNAP E&T ME, Medicaid, Child Care Assistance, and ongoing QC audit. WCDSS also performs in-house random case samplings of SNAP, TA and HEAP cases. Staff receive information via teleconference, in-person meetings and memorandum. Central Program Office conducts both large and small program meetings on a monthly basis as well as developing and supporting training seminars specifically developed for particular topics such as Domestic Violence, Fair Hearing preparation, immigration and eligibility of refugees, homelessness and SNAP supportive retraining. These meetings serve as a means of introducing important changes in regulation as well as review of procedures and forms in an effort to maintain the quality and efficiency of the Department.

Prison Re-Entry Program: The Re-Entry Program assists Westchester County residents who are released from the County jail and New York State prisons. The residents in need of assistance from this department with re-entry into the community are assessed prior to their release date. The following areas have been identified as items needed to assist the re-entry individuals with the department's application process for Temporary Assistance benefits: housing and shelter needs, treatment goals, employability status and the coordination of services with other departments and agencies. The department works with each ex-offender towards the achievement of their goals in order to deter recidivism. Since its inception on April 15, 2019 until June 30, 2024 this department has assisted 757 County residents released from the County jail. This department has also assisted 733 County residents who have been released from the state prison system during the period of August 1, 2018 to June 30, 2024.

Mobile Stabilization & Mediation Response Unit: The Mobile Stabilization & Mediation Response Unit (MSMRU) originated through an OCFS Family First Act Grant allotted to four counties including Westchester, Monroe, Onondaga and Albany. The grant was intended to address the high number of disruptions in children's foster care placements. These disruptions led to repeated replacements, a higher percentage of congregate care placements, and delays in children obtaining permanency. The MSMRU had a soft launch in 2023, starting with two senior social caseworkers and a clinician from the Clinical and Behavioral Assessment Unit (CBAU) who assisted with stabilization efforts. During this period, WCDSS conducted a needs assessment while collaborating with OCFS on

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the implementation plan. Once the plan was approved, OCFS released three grants: \$200,000 to staff and maintain the mobile unit, \$150,000 to staff full-time Family Peer Advocates, and \$60,000 to provide supportive domestic violence services to children exposed to domestic violence. The program is composed of three tracks: stabilization, mediation & behavioral change, and advocacy. Initially, referrals consisted of children placed in foster care, but the program has expanded to include other disciplines within the Department of Social Services (DSS), such as the housing program, Preventive Services, and community-based referrals (e.g., schools, labor trafficking).

The team began engaging with the community through various events to increase awareness and demonstrate their commitment to providing preventative care and support. By March 2024, essential staff were added such as a Family Peer Advocate, a Youth Peer Advocate, and a Labor Maintenance Worker responsible for driving the mobile unit. Since its inception, the program has received complete buy-in from both internal and community providers partnering with DSS, such as DCMH Project Alliance, YAI, and local schools. Data from May 2022 through May 2024 reflects the program's success. Of 56 referrals, 36 children in care had their placements stabilized and remained in their foster homes, 18 children remained in the community with support services, 1 was hospitalized, and 1 was discharged to his parent. Remarkably, there were zero new placements. The MSMRU's innovative approach has proven to be an invaluable resource, reducing disruptions in foster care placements and supporting children's stability and permanency in Westchester County.

Child Welfare - Family First Prevention Services Act (FFPSA): required DSS significantly restructure delivery of Child Welfare Preventive Services in 2021 and prioritized keeping more children safely in their homes. FFPSA was implemented across New York State in September 2021. FFPSA legislation impacts funding for children entering foster care with specific Federal and State benchmarks. This includes reducing the number of youth residing in congregate care settings to 12% of all children in foster care, greater oversight over children in institutional placements and 50% of all children in foster care to reside with kin/fictive kin homes. FFPSA also

increased federal funding to 50% of the cost of in-home preventive services delivered by approved Evidenced-Based Programs (EBMs).

With the implementation of the Family First Prevention Services Act (FFPSA), the Department of Social Services (DSS) has made significant strides in improving FFPSA metrics. One notable achievement is the substantial reduction in the number of children in congregate care, which has decreased to 9%. This is significantly below the 12% State standard. While the percentage of children in kinship foster care has remained steady at 43%, close to the rate of non-kinship care, there has been a notable increase in diverting foster care placements through Child Safety Conferences. Based on the current monthly average, DSS expects to serve approximately 6,800 families this year. Currently, as of June 2024, 323 children are in foster care, while 1,096 children are receiving preventive services. The significant decrease in foster care placements and the increase in families receiving preventive services result from Child Welfare's trauma-informed efforts to keep more children safely in their homes and reduce the number entering foster care. These accomplishments highlight DSS's commitment to prioritizing preventive services and family-based placements, ensuring that children grow up in safe, stable, and nurturing environments. By continuing to focus on early intervention and support, DSS aims to sustain and build on these successes, ultimately improving outcomes for children and families in Westchester County.

Strengthening DSS Preventive Services System: The Westchester County Department of Social Services (WCDSS) has made substantial progress in implementing the Family First Prevention Services Act (FFPSA) and strengthening its preventive services system. Phase 1 of the Family First implementation was completed in June 2023, showcasing several pivotal initiatives aimed at supporting at-risk families and preventing foster care placements. One significant change is the expanded definition of "candidates for foster care." Now, children identified for preventive services by community-based providers outside the formal child welfare system are included. This broader definition facilitates earlier interventions and support for at-risk families, aiming to prevent an SCR call or placement before a crisis escalates. It also aims to reduce the disproportionality of black and brown children in the child welfare system. Aftercare services have also been enhanced. The Aftercare contract now includes Prevention aftercare, aligning with the Public Health Model of serving families. This approach

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serves families with economic, concrete, or other preventive service needs through primary prevention programs without opening a formal service case. The outcomes are monitored at the Program Office level, ensuring accountability while reducing SCR calls and/or potential foster care placements. A key component of WCDSS's efforts to support the work is comprehensive staff training. The department has invested in staff development, particularly in Motivational Interviewing (MI) training for all caseworkers, supervisors, and managers. MI is an evidence-based engagement approach designed to promote behavior change and improve outcomes across various domains of family life. By assisting clients in progressing through the stages of change, MI aims to reduce the length of stay in preventive services or foster care.

Utilization monitoring is another crucial aspect of WCDSS's strategy. To ensure accountability and track progress, WCDSS has implemented a manual system for monitoring the utilization of both general and evidence-based services. This tracking is crucial for Title IV-E reimbursement and provides valuable insights into service effectiveness. However, recognizing the limitations of a manual system, the department is exploring the development of an automated tracking system. This technological upgrade will streamline data collection, enhance accuracy, and provide real-time insights into service utilization and outcomes.

As WCDSS continues to evolve its preventive services system, the focus remains on building a robust, responsive, and evidence-based network of support for families. By combining expanded services, cultural sensitivity, evidence-based practices, and skilled intervention, WCDSS is working to prevent foster care placements, and support stronger, more resilient families and communities.

Disproportionate Minority Representation (DMR) Data shows that families of color are disproportionately represented in the Child Welfare system and are likely to be linked to services culturally misaligned with the family and the community they reside in. To reduce this disparity, WCDSS implemented strategies to identify and expand services that are more representative of the children and families served. There were concerted efforts to target small business and minority-owned service providers and WCDSS went from 0% minority-owned to 21% minority owned services that provide direct prevention services to children and/or families. In addition to expanding services representative of the families we serve, WCDSS Office

of Policy, Planning, and Program Development shifted to a data-driven approach. This has led to the centralization and coordination of the service referrals along with enhanced monitoring of service delivery and outcomes. The WCDSS Foster Care and Preventive Services Unit was established to support staff with quickly identifying and obtaining the services families need. This restructuring of preventive service delivery included a gap analysis to determine the specific array of services needed, and gaps in service availability along with tracking and measuring provider's performance with meeting the needs of families. The unit's task is to improve the quality of direct services, increase service accessibility and provide accountability and coordination among WCDSS and service providers to improve capacity of families to meet the needs of their children. As of June 2024, 1,096 children have been referred for preventive services.

In addressing DMR as it pertains to children in care and children entering foster care, OCFS data indicates continued disproportionality in the number of black and brown children entering care compared to the percentage of black and brown children in the County. Current data reflects that the Department is making progress in reducing the length of time children remain in foster care. Through a two-year grant from the Redlich Horwitz Foundation (RHF), DSS and RHF are partnering to reduce the disproportional minority representation of families throughout Westchester County starting with reports made to the State Central Registry and children entering foster care during the course of an SCR investigation. Based on data, Westchester implemented two DMR initiatives. These initiatives had two purposes: (1) to help educate the community about the appropriate and beneficial use of the SCR line in an effort to decrease unnecessary SCR calls, encourage the increased use of the centralized H.E.A.R.S. (Help, Empower, Advocate, Reassure & Support) line, and move mandated reporters towards a supporting rather than reporting model when there is no suspicion of abuse or neglect; and (2) to strengthen WCDSS relationships with children, youth, and families by actively sharing healing-centered information and concrete connections concerning our main priority; Helping keep families together safely and resiliently. The first initiative is based in the Mount Vernon school system. The WCDSS Schools-Based Liaison Project (SBL), is funded by RHF over a 2-year pilot period and started in late 2023. The SBL helps bridge the gap between the schools and child welfare systems to advocate and support social, educational, and overall wellness outcomes through collaboration and integration of the school, the community, and child and family-serving systems resulting in increased

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linkages to prevention and family preservation services. It's also geared to support increased school attendance. The second DMR initiative with Redlich is an Equity Coaching initiative for supervisors and managers which began in March 2024. In tandem with consultants from the University of Connecticut, the program employs a TCS (training, coaching, and supervision) approach, focusing on vital topics like trauma-informed understanding, healing-centered approach, and anti-racist practices that influence a child welfare practitioner's decision-making skills when working with children, youth, and families. Overall, the program aims to foster a culture of equity and inclusion within the Westchester County Department of Social Services, focusing on practical application and sustainability, which includes more reflective decision-making and changes to policy and practice.

Clinical Behavioral and Assessment Unit To ensure that congregate care is used only as a last resort for youth entering care, the Family First Prevention Services Act (FFPSA) mandates that local counties conduct clinical assessments of all youths placed in congregate care to determine appropriate level of placement. This is a prerequisite for the County to receive federal reimbursement for the youth's care. These clinical assessments must be performed by licensed Qualified Individuals (QIs) approved by the state. To meet this requirement, the Westchester County Department of Social Services (WCDSS) established the Clinical and Behavioral Assessment Unit (CBAU). This unit is staffed by experienced Senior Social Caseworkers, who are also Licensed Master Social Workers or Mental Health Counselors. The QI's role is to assess a child and determine the appropriateness of a placement in a Qualified Residential Treatment Program (QRTP) or whether the youth's needs can be met by family members, in a foster family home, or in a specified non-congregate care setting. These QI assessments are time-sensitive, ensuring the County can claim Title IV-E reimbursement for the maintenance costs of the youth's placement. The assessments completed by WCDSS's CBAU have been highlighted as examples of optimal QI assessments during state forums. Over the past year, the role of the CBAU has expanded to support various programmatic needs within child welfare, including the QI Long Stayers Review (LSR), Sibling Consultations, and Initial Assessments for children entering foster care. The Long Stayer Reviews (LSR) focus on youth in foster care who remain in congregate care, specifically in QRTPs, for extended periods. FFPSA has set placement thresholds for these youth to reduce their length of stay (LOS) in such settings. If extensions to the LOS

are necessary, they must be approved by the Commissioner of the New York State Office of Children and Family Services (OCFS) or their designee. The licensed clinicians in the CBAU ensure that residential facilities are accountable for helping youths reach their goals or justify requests for extended stays.

The CBAU has proven to be an invaluable resource for WCDSS. Westchester County boasts a 100% timely submission rate of QI assessments and a 100% timeliness for 60-day court reviews for QRTP placements. To date, the CBAU has evaluated 102 youths: 87 were deemed QRTP level, 3 were recommended for the EMPOWER program, 9 were recommended for therapeutic foster homes or discharge, and 3 were provided with preventive programs without entering foster care. The CBAU clinicians have saved the County funds that can be redirected toward prevention services. They have also reduced assessment and turnaround times, ensuring that children receive proper interventions and treatment promptly. This efficiency and effectiveness demonstrate WCDSS's commitment to optimizing care for vulnerable youth while maximizing resources and support for prevention services.

Family Team Decision Making Meetings: In response to the NYS ADM of 2020, the Westchester County Department of Social Services (WCDSS) adopted the Family Team Decision Making (FTDM) model to enhance family engagement in child welfare decisions. Implemented in June 2021, FTDM is a collaborative approach that includes family members in all decisions related to child safety, change of placement, reunification, or other permanency plans. These meetings involve parents or caregivers, children aged 10 and over when appropriate, and a family support network. Families are encouraged to bring their support network to ensure their voices and stories are heard and valued. Decisions are made by consensus prioritizing the family's goals while maintaining the child's safety as the primary focus. The primary goal of FTDM is to reduce the number of children entering foster care by identifying the most effective in-home preventive services that meet the family's needs. As of June 2024, WCDSS facilitated 324 Child Safety Conferences. Of these, 209 children (65%) were diverted from foster care, marking a 14% increase from the previous year. Additionally, 235 families (73%) accepted preventive services intervention, an 8% increase, while 73 families (22%) declined services but did not require foster care placement. Among the children placed in care, 50 entered kinship foster care, and 34 entered non-kinship care. Parent

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Advocates play a crucial role in FTDM meetings by providing support to parents and helping them navigate the child welfare process. They offer unbiased assistance, support parents' understanding of the child welfare system, and can effectively participate in the decision-making process. Recognizing the importance of Parent Advocates, WCDSS contracted with a service provider to supply parent advocates for FTDMs and to offer continued support and advocacy as needed. The integration of Parent Advocates has been instrumental in both the Family Team meetings and the DSS Mobile Response program, providing essential support to families and helping them navigate the complexities of the child welfare system. This approach underscores WCDSS's commitment to fostering a collaborative, family-centered process that prioritizes the safety and well-being of children while empowering families.

Safe Harbor Program one of the few “graduated” counties that continues to get OCFS Safe Harbor funding and is the only county which has a Safe Harbor Unit as part of the child welfare framework. Operating under the laws and guidelines of the New York Safe Harbor for Exploited Children Act (2008), the unit provides case management services for Human Trafficking survivors and youth who are at-risk for trafficking as they are exhibiting behaviors/indicators commonly associated with trafficking. From June 2023 through June 2024, the Safe Harbor unit received 218 referrals and since the Unit's inception in 2013, 208 youths were federally confirmed victims, 195 youths were NYS confirmed victims, and 14 out of 14 submitted referrals to the New York State Office of Temporary and Disability Assistance (OTDA) were determined to have met the criteria for confirmation as a Human Trafficking victim in New York State. The Safe Harbor Program has been integrated into the child welfare framework and as a response to combat Human Trafficking, is able to offer the Safe Harbor Psychoeducational groups. The group curriculum continues to integrate a model which empowers our youth to become experts in their own lives, as well as Support Circles which afford our youth a safe space to begin their story-telling processes. The Safe Harbor Psychoeducational Groups also provide youth with an opportunity to work with an art therapist and incorporate restorative healing through Creative Expression. WCDSS has incorporated the Mentoring Program within the psychoeducational groups for survivors who have stayed out of “the life” and become young mentors to the new youth. The mentors are selected based on overall experience and progress through past group participation and their interview performance. Each mentor serves in their role for one group cohort (12 weeks) and

receive a stipend of \$25/group as well as transportation to and from the groups. The Safe Harbor Program also collaborates with My Life My Choice to provide clinical consultations to Safe Harbor staff to address vicarious trauma and provide additional support for complex case situations. Through the OCFS grant, the Safe Harbor Program continues to provide bi-annual youth retreats which with the Anti-Trafficking Task Force have afforded youth to come together in a teen conference format and participate in workshops focused on leadership, self-reflection, and healing through creative process, as well as provide linkage to positive community leaders focusing on developing their character and personal growth. Additionally, there is programming for positive youth initiatives centered around hip hop dance therapy and a podcast to help fuel trauma healing and improve mental health. Through ongoing collaborations with the International Organization for Adolescent and Anti-Trafficking Task Force, the Safe Harbor Program was able to afford youth an on-campus experience at Montclair State University through the Possibilities Program in 2023 and plans to provide a similar experience in 2024. Through an OVC grant, the Safe Harbor Program has collaborated in creating a virtual mentoring program connecting at-risk youth with survivors and there is a shift to present the Internet Safety Training to youth in foster care including family-based foster, particularly for foster parents fostering middle school aged children and teens. The Safe Harbor Program continues to bring awareness to preventing Human Trafficking through presentations at Community Network Meetings and participating in panel discussions within the county. In Fall of 2023, the Safe Harbor Program hosted a Community Awareness Campaign which not only highlighted the youth led video podcast, “What's Strong With You?” but also provided an opportunity for the community to hear from a lived experience expert as well as a youth-led panel discussion. The Safe Harbor Program completed their first audit with the Office of Temporary Disability Assistance (OTDA) and scored well in the area of identification, documentation, and provision of services to youth in Westchester.

Legal Services Family Representation Project: NYS Office of Indigent Legal Services awarded a three-year grant to Westchester County and Legal Services Hudson Valley (LSHV) to enable LSHV provide legal representation to families during SCR investigations and subsequent Family Court involvement. Legal Service of Hudson Valley was granted another three-year grant to continue to provide high-quality legal representation to Westchester Families. Families involved in Child Welfare

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investigations receive legal advice and work with the LSHV social work team throughout parent's involvement with Child Welfare. Westchester County DSS strongly supports this approach of representation during an SCR investigation understanding that it provides a unique opportunity for parents to feel empowered and have a greater voice in determining case outcomes. A protocol between LSHV and DSS provides the framework for communication between LSHV and DSS staff. LSHV advocates participate in child welfare TDM meetings and other case planning meetings that include the parent. There are monthly meetings between LSHV and Westchester Program Development to monitor the project and respond to any barriers to service in real time. In May 2024, Westchester County Department of Services and Legal Services participated with other leadership teams in the Redlich Horowitz Foundations Keeping Families Together Summit. The summit brought together child welfare and community members from ten NY counties currently working on community-centered and equity-driven strategies to narrow the front door to child welfare and enhance family resiliency without separation.

Cross System Unit: (CSU) interfaces with Probation, DCMH and through an interdepartmental agreement with DSS/DCMH and Probation. Parents seeking help for their youngster that meets the PINS Criteria (age 11-17) are referred to Cross Systems Unit by DCMH and Probation where families receive Preventive Service programming with wraparound services. The mission of the Cross Systems Unit is to provide a multi-disciplinary approach in creating family-driven, strength-based, individualized responses that promote the safety and well-being of youth and families throughout Westchester County. This approach allows for a complete and thorough assessment of family's strengths and challenges and for an appropriate response to the identified needs. PINS Reform of 2021 emphasized use of delivery of services safely in the community to exhaust all diversion efforts prior to court involvement and PINS diversion youth cannot be detained in non-secure or secured facilities. A new placement option was created under pre-Dispositional placement (PDP) where the court can utilize out of home settings provided by local Department of Social Services. After December 29, 2022, no youth under the age of 13 may be remanded to secure detention unless they have allegedly committed a homicide offense. OCFS provided directives for local departments of social services to establish differential response programs for youth under 12 who, but for their age, could be subject to a delinquency petition. The Cross System Unit provides the differential response to meet the new law

requirements and provides OCFS with the quarterly data. Youth under the age group no longer fall under the definition of juvenile delinquency and, therefore, cannot be arrested or processed. Instead, they are referred to the DSS Cross System Unit for screening, assessment, and service delivery. In 2023, CSU serviced 2,740 PINS Diversion children and from January 2024 to June 2024, CSU served 1,246 children.

Safe and Together Model: WCDSS receives approximately 6,500 reports of suspected child maltreatment annually. On average, 35% involved concerns related to domestic violence. In 2024, Child Welfare adopted the Safe and Together model of working with families impacted by domestic violence. This model fills the gaps in knowledge and practice and assists all systems touching on domestic violence and child well-being to become domestic abuse-informed, supporting child well-being and safety across all partners in the domestic violence community. The guiding principles of Safe and Together include 1: Keeping children safe and together with the non-offending parent, 2: Partnering with the non-offending parent as our default approach, and 3: Intervening with the perpetrator to reduce risk and harm to the child(ren). This child-centered approach has shown to be effective in reducing the rate of protective removals because it is grounded in the idea that child welfare has the potential to be a powerful ally to adults and children harmed by a domestic violence perpetrator's behaviors and that systems are most effective when they focus on child well-being while partnering with the adult survivor to increase the safety and well-being of children and the stability, safety, self-determination, and satisfaction of families. By the end of 2024, the target is to have all WCDSS staff in Child Welfare trained in the Safe and Together Model while also incorporating coaching and case consultations to support a sustainable practice shift.

Office of Organizational Enhancement & Professional Development (OEPD): In March 2022, DSS established the Office of Organizational Enhancement & Professional Development (OEPD) with the mission to enhance the quality of professionalism and service provision offered by the Westchester County Department of Social Services through coaching and professional development efforts. OEPD focuses on promoting equity and wellness for WCDSS employees while providing high-quality learning opportunities to foster a safe culture of continuous learning and improvement. The program supports the Department in streamlining

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processes and improving internal communication to cultivate increased efficiency and collaboration.

Professional Development

OEPD supports the multifaceted Department goals as well as individual and professional growth through effective training, planning and change management. To date, OEPD coordinates trainings delivered by the state in response to federal, state, and local mandatory program requirements for all social service staff. This includes virtual training as well as in-person instructor led learning. In 2023, the unit developed and supported a model for structured development of newly hired staff in Child Welfare. OEPD continues to provide customized coordination and support for Child Welfare trainees.

OEPD has created and implemented various learning programs on topics including but not limited to writing effective progress notes, performance evaluations, emotional intelligence, psychological safety, and leadership. The program has leveraged State training relationships to bring in-person skill enhancement training to Department staff. Some examples include, Critical Thinking in Casework, Developing Junior Leaders, and Communication Across the Generational Divide. The unit conducted a 2022 learning needs assessment as well as a 2023 DEI survey both with over 60% staff response and are working collaboratively with leadership to develop short-term and long-term professional development and equity strategy goals. OEPD is also supporting higher education opportunities for staff through the release of policies on accessing field placement support and higher education funding. OEPD coordinates access to graduate school funding for Child Welfare staff through the Social Work Education Consortium at SUNY Albany. In 2023, over \$19K were disbursed in education funding and the program is on track to exceed that amount in 2024.

Leadership Development

In 2024, OEPD has focused professional development strategies toward developing a department of leaders. The program has contracted with the University of Denver, Butler Institute for Families, to provide a comprehensive and dynamic leadership development services. This includes executive coaching and assessments for senior leaders, Leadership Academy for managers and directors, and coaching skill development for supervisors. Additionally, OEPD has coordinated with

leads from the Office of Children and Family Services (OCFS) to bring the Supervisor Certificate Training Program to Department supervisors. This learning series is facilitated by The Learning & Development Projects at the Silberman School of Social Work at Hunter College. The departmental focus on leadership includes the development of a draft policy on supervisory requirements and adaption of a supervision framework.

Equity Strategies

Since 2022, OEPD has created and managed the Department's equity action plan. In 2023, OEPD messaging and monitoring of state-mandated courses led to a significant increase with required learning related to diversity, equity, inclusion and belonging such as Implicit Bias training for all staff and Blind Removal training for Child Welfare. Since 2022, OEPD continues to coordinate various learning programs to promote diversity and belong within the Department and in our community interactions. Some of these learning opportunities include the Kempe International Conference, Undoing Racism Workshops, and Supporting Race Equity in Child Welfare. In 2024, OEPD is expanding its equity strategies through a contract with ReadySet Solutions. This collaboration will add capacity to offer coaching and learning opportunities for expanded equity implementation teams and will support in creating employee resource groups.

Employee Wellness & Wellbeing

OEPD leads employee engagement and wellbeing efforts for the Department. Since 2023, OEPD has coordinated and implemented an annual kindness campaign to emphasize the importance of maintaining a safe workplace culture. This initiative includes the development of asynchronous web-based learning programs. The team also has taken the lead in the Department's involvement in the National Child Welfare Workforce Institute's (NCWWI) Breakthrough Series Collaborative (BSC), and other efforts geared toward staff engagement and sustainability. In 2024, OEPD has contracted with a state approved vendor to bring Safety Training to all staff who make community visits as part of their primary role and function.

Organizational Enhancement

OEPD provides concrete organizational enhancement to the various program areas within the Department by providing support in creating manuals, policies, that support more efficient workflow for staff. Each year, OEPD presents at the New York Public Welfare Association conference